



Sociological Frameworks

Durkheim and Structural Functionalism

➤ **Functionalist approach.**

Robert Merton and Talcott Parsons came up with this approach. Influential approach which guided studies on social stratification in India till the 1970s..

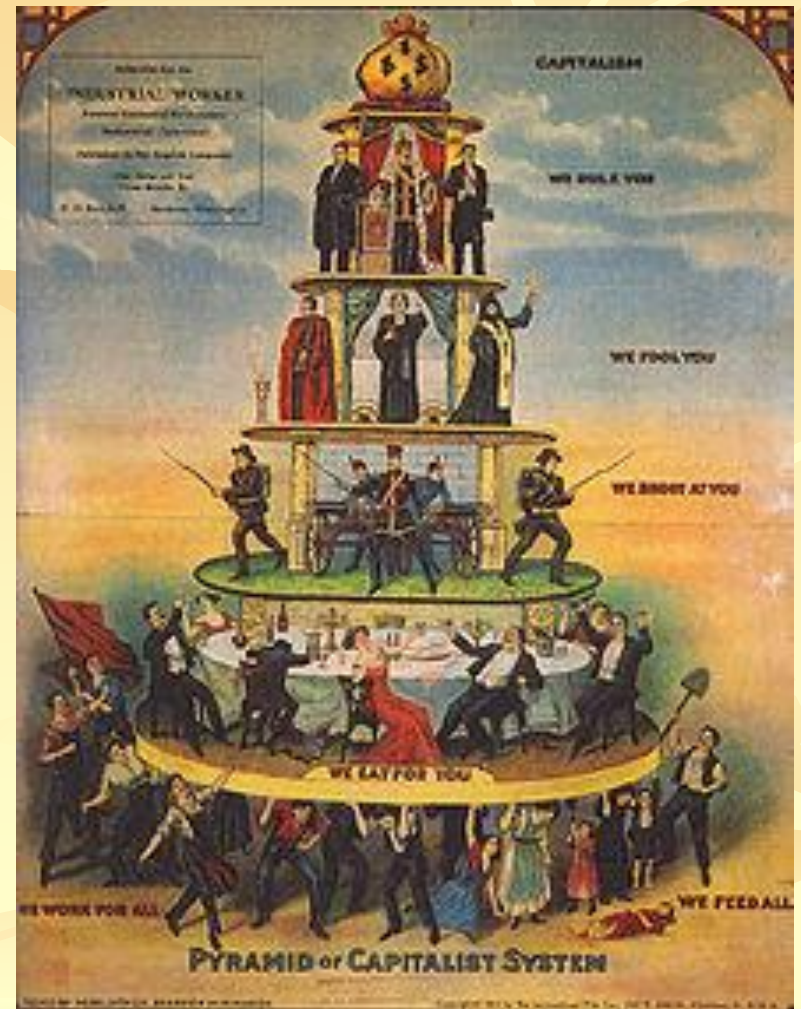
Social differences, and inequalities are present in order to maintain the system. Stratification is seen as *essential*, performing a certain role. Various participants and groups consent to this stratification, because they are so organically connected to it. In some ways, the functionalist approach rationalises social stratification.

Conflict theories: Marxist approach

Conflict theories see an exercise of power in the process and functioning of social stratification.

Marxist approach.

Dialectical. Social stratification is not treated as a given. Caste for instance was originally not determined by birth. It *became* a system that was based on birth. So Marxists try to understand how and why stratification happened. CLASSES as largely economic in nature.



Conflict theories: Weberian approach

This uses **class, status and power** to explain social stratification.

Weber argued that **status distinctions** could appear *independently* of **economic class**.

Weber saw 'power' as an important factor. This power was related to membership in an organisation – and was not necessarily related to economic status or social status.

WEALTH, POWER and PRESTIGE – together determine the “Weberian Class”.

M.N. Srinivas and the '*Dominant Caste*' analysis of Indian society. This dominant caste analysis has been successfully used by sociologists to explain political trends in India.

BASES OF SOCIAL STRATIFICATION



WEALTH – associated with education, income and occupation

POWER – ability of one party to affect the behavior of another party



PRESTIGE – the distinction or reputation and how people are subjectively evaluated by others